1

IT WAS 22 MAY 1991. SEVEN O'CLOCK, WEDNESDAY MORNING. TOO early to wake up. Especially after a late night. Anirudhya tried to figure out what she was saying by waving around the morning paper. He fumbled with the bunch of newspapers his wife had dropped right on top of him and said, 'Rajiv Gandhi is dead.' Headlines across the newspapers said the very same thing—the former Prime Minister of India had been assassinated the previous night at an election rally in Sriperumbudur, Tamil Nadu.

Anirudhya's wife, Rupa, had gone back to the kitchen. The telephone rang. Anirudhya picked up the receiver. The coordinator of the news desk of *India Today* magazine was on the line. Anirudhya had been called to office early. He had been working for *India Today* for just over a month and was always looking for a good story. But this appeared much more than that. The assassination of a former head of state who was tipped to be returning to power was much more than what he had been doing—investigative pieces on kickbacks paid in defence deals, political appointments of bureaucrats and narco-terrorism. He had left his previous job at another newspaper to chase bigger investigative stories. It seemed he had got that served on a platter.

Anirudhya parked his Kinetic Honda scooter in Connaught Place F-block and climbed the narrow, steep stairs that led to one of India's most respected news fortnightlies. The magazine's large newsroom encircled by editors' cabins was usually quiet until about eleven, even if a sub-editor or two were at work. As Anirudhya peeped into the coordinator Harpal Singh's cubicle to check if there was any message from Editor-in-Chief Aroon Purie, he called from behind him, standing at the door of Managing Editor Inderjit Badhwar. Badhwar had been instrumental in getting Anirudhya over to *India Today*.